

KEEPING THE LIGHTS ON

The central highlands of Sri Lanka, have a distinct weather and climate from the rest of the island. It is cooler, the scorching heat of the blazing sun that torments the dry zone, is not for the residents of Hapugasdeniya, Akiriya, who enjoy a more temperate climate. However, the frequent rain and the strong winds cause many challenges. This is exacerbated when it damages the electricity lines and causes power shortages.

Niluka Abeywardhana, is a small business owner and a mother who supports a family of six. She runs a mini-garment enterprise, and employs four women employees from her community. The business is a very important source of income that support all five of their households.

“I run a small garment business and employ four women,” she explains. “But the biggest problem I faced was with regards to electricity.”



In this part of the country, frequent rain and strong winds often lead to electricity disruptions. Sometimes, power would be unavailable for days.

“When the electricity goes out, my business comes to a complete stop,” Niluka says. “I cannot provide work for the women who work under me during those days. This hampers my ability to finish production or deliver orders to institutions on time.”

For a small enterprise operating on tight margins, delays meant more than inconvenience — they meant financial loss, broken trust with buyers, and unstable income for workers. At the same time, rising electricity tariffs made costs increasingly difficult to bear.



Across Sri Lanka, women-led micro and small enterprises are among the hardest hit during periods of economic and energy instability. When electricity is unreliable or unaffordable, businesses like Niluka's are often the first to suffer, even though they provide critical income and employment at community level.



“The electricity bill was also becoming very hard for me to manage,”

That changed when Niluka received a solar power system with the funding support of the Government of Japan through its Japanese Supplementary Budget (JSB) and implemented by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) in Sri Lanka, under the 'Empowering Women Smallholders Farmers through Renewable Energy-Based Agriculture Modernization Technologies' project.

“At a time when I was facing many difficulties, I received this solar system through this project,”

Most importantly, the system has allowed her to provide continuous employment to the women who work with her — even during power cuts or bad weather.

“After receiving the solar system, the electricity problems I faced were solved,” Niluka explains. “Now I can complete my production on time and deliver orders to institutions without delay.”

Any surplus electricity generated is also used for household needs, further easing financial pressure.



“I can now confidently give my workers the opportunity to come to work every day,”

For her, the solar system has become more than a power source — it is a foundation for confidence and growth.



“This electricity system has been a great support in moving my business forward with strength and peace of mind,”

By ensuring reliable energy for a small enterprise, the intervention has helped protect women's employment, sustain local production, and strengthen household resilience. In Hapugasdeniya, keeping the lights on has meant keeping livelihoods alive, proving that small, strategic investments in energy security can safeguard women's work, dignity, and economic independence, even in uncertain times.

“To be honest, I no longer feel afraid of the electricity bill,”

